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  KEERTHI KUMAR V - 3D PORTFOLIO + ADMIN PANEL
  FULL 2-MONTH PLAN (MERN, JavaScript only, no TypeScript)
  Theme: Original "Doom-inspired" empire (dark steel + glowing green + gold)
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HOW TO USE THIS FILE
- Read Sections 1-4 once to understand the whole project.
- Then follow Section 9 (the day-by-day schedule) every day.
- Tick off the checklist in Section 13 before launch.

CORE RULES
1. AI helps with DESIGN (concept art, 3D mask, copywriting, mockups) and
   with EXPLAINING concepts. YOU write the code yourself.
2. Never paste code you do not understand. If stuck for 30 minutes, ask AI
   to explain the problem, not to solve it.
3. Commit to Git every day with a clear message.
4. If you fall behind, cut features (sound, cursor, particles). NEVER cut
   the backend, the admin panel, or the main 3D mask.
5. Month 1 = Backend + Admin Panel. Month 2 = Public Portfolio + Animations.
   Do not start Month 2 until the admin panel works end to end.

TIME PER DAY
- Monday to Friday: 1.5 to 2 hours (light work: learn one thing, build one piece)
- Saturday and Sunday: 5 to 6 hours each (heavy building days)
- Total: about 130 to 150 hours over 8 weeks

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SECTION 1: PROJECT OVERVIEW
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What you are building:
  A. A public portfolio website (3D, animated, cinematic) for Keerthi Kumar V.
  B. A private admin panel where you manage ALL content (projects, skills,
     experience, education, about, resume, messages) without touching code.
  C. A backend REST API with authentication, uploads, and a database.

Why this impresses recruiters:
  - It proves you can build a complete full-stack product (auth, CRUD,
    uploads, deployment), not just a static page.
  - The 3D hero and smooth animations show frontend craft.
  - The admin panel shows real-world thinking.

Data flow (this is the heart of the project):
  1. You add a project in the Admin Panel.
  2. The admin form sends it to POST /api/projects (protected by JWT cookie).
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  3. Express validates the data, uploads images to Cloudinary, saves to MongoDB.
  4. The public portfolio calls GET /api/projects using TanStack Query.
  5. Cards appear with animation. You never edit code to update content.

Build pipeline for EVERY section (always in this order):
  Mongoose model -> API route/controller -> Admin form -> Public section -> Animation

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SECTION 2: BRAND, THEME, AND THE DOOM-INSPIRED CONCEPT
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Name:      KEERTHI KUMAR V
Monogram:  KKV (a sharp metallic emblem, create it with Ideogram)
Title:     Full-Stack MERN Developer
Tagline ideas:
  - "I don't follow trends. I rule the stack."
  - "Code is my empire."
  - "Ruler of the MERN stack."

Concept: "The Empire of Keerthi". The portfolio is your kingdom and you are
its ruler. Every section is a part of the empire:

  Hero        -> The Throne Room   (3D mask, name, title, buttons)
  About       -> The Ruler         (your story, photo, stats, resume)
  Skills      -> The Armory        (tech stack as weapons/relics)
  Projects    -> Conquests         (your projects)
  Experience  -> Chronicles        (timeline of work and education)
  Contact     -> Summon Me         (contact form and social links)

IMPORTANT - LEGAL AND SMART NOTE:
Dr. Doom's mask and name belong to Marvel. For a public portfolio that
recruiters will see, do NOT copy the official mask, use Marvel models/art,
or write "Doom" or "Marvel" on the site. Instead create an ORIGINAL
Doom-inspired mask: a hooded, riveted steel faceplate, narrow glowing green
eye slits, a "KKV" crest engraved on the forehead, your own design details.
It keeps the same dark royal mood, avoids copyright trouble, and shows more
originality, which recruiters value.

Design system:
  Background        #07090A  (near black)
  Steel             #2B3338
  Light steel       #4A5560
  Primary accent    #2EFF8B  (glow green)
  Secondary accent  #C9A227  (royal gold)
  Text              #E6EAEA
  Headings font     Cinzel or Cormorant Garamond (serif, royal feel)
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  Body font         Inter
  Effects           fog, green rim light, ember particles, film grain
  Admin panel       Reuse the same palette so both sites feel like one brand,
                    but keep it calmer (less glow, more readability).

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SECTION 3: TECH STACK AND LIBRARIES (WITH WHY)
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FRONTEND (client/)
  React 18 + Vite ........... fast dev server, plain JavaScript
  React Router DOM .......... routing for public pages and /admin pages
  Tailwind CSS .............. styling with a custom theme (your palette)
  Axios ..................... HTTP client with credentials (cookies)
  TanStack Query ............ fetching, caching, loading/error states,
                              mutations, cache invalidation
  React Hook Form + Zod ..... forms and validation
  Zustand ................... small global state (auth status, UI state)
  GSAP + ScrollTrigger ...... scroll animations, timeline drawing, counters
  Lenis ..................... smooth scrolling
  Framer Motion ............. page transitions, hover effects, modals
  Three.js .................. 3D engine
  @react-three/fiber (R3F) .. Three.js inside React
  @react-three/drei ......... helpers: useGLTF, Environment, ScrollControls
  @react-three/postprocessing  bloom (the green glow on eyes)
  react-hot-toast ........... notifications
  lucide-react / react-icons  icons
  react-helmet-async ........ SEO meta tags
  Tiptap (optional) ......... rich text for long project descriptions
  Recharts (optional) ....... dashboard charts

BACKEND (server/)
  Node.js + Express ......... REST API
  MongoDB Atlas + Mongoose .. database and schemas
  jsonwebtoken + bcryptjs ... authentication
  cookie-parser ............. read httpOnly cookies
  Multer + Cloudinary ....... image and PDF uploads
  Zod or express-validator .. request validation
  helmet .................... secure HTTP headers
  cors ...................... allow your frontend domain with credentials
  express-rate-limit ........ stop spam on login and contact form
  express-mongo-sanitize .... block NoSQL injection
  Nodemailer or Resend ...... email you when someone sends a message
  dotenv, morgan, nodemon ... config, logging, dev auto-restart

TOOLS
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  Git + GitHub, VS Code, Postman or Thunder Client
  Figma (layouts), Blender (mask cleanup), gltf-transform (Draco compression)
  Coolors (palette), Lighthouse (performance)

AI DESIGN TOOLS
  Claude ............... concept, copywriting, prompts, explanations
  Midjourney / Ideogram / Flux ... mask concept art and the KKV logo
  Meshy / Tripo3D / Hunyuan3D ... turn the mask image into a 3D model
  v0.dev / Figma Make / Google Stitch ... UI mockups for REFERENCE ONLY
  (Rebuild every component yourself in React and Tailwind.)

DEPLOYMENT
  Backend ........ Render or Railway
  Frontend ....... Vercel (portfolio and admin can be one app, /admin route)
  Database ....... MongoDB Atlas (free tier)
  Files .......... Cloudinary

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SECTION 4: FOLDER STRUCTURE
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portfolio/
|
|-- server/
|   |-- config/
|   |     db.js                (MongoDB connection)
|   |     cloudinary.js        (Cloudinary config)
|   |-- models/
|   |     Admin.js             (email, hashed password)
|   |     Profile.js           (about/hero data)
|   |     Project.js
|   |     Skill.js
|   |     Experience.js
|   |     Education.js
|   |     Message.js
|   |-- controllers/
|   |     authController.js, profileController.js, projectController.js,
|   |     skillController.js, experienceController.js,
|   |     educationController.js, messageController.js
|   |-- routes/
|   |     authRoutes.js, profileRoutes.js, projectRoutes.js,
|   |     skillRoutes.js, experienceRoutes.js, educationRoutes.js,
|   |     messageRoutes.js
|   |-- middleware/
|   |     auth.js              (verify JWT cookie)
|   |     error.js             (central error handler)
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|   |     upload.js             (Multer)
|   |     validate.js           (Zod/validator wrapper)
|   |     rateLimit.js
|   |-- utils/
|   |     sendEmail.js, generateToken.js, slugify.js
|   |-- .env                    (never commit this)
|   |-- .gitignore
|   |-- server.js
|
|-- client/
    |-- public/                 (favicon, og-image, draco decoder, mask.glb)
    |-- src/
        |-- api/
        |     axiosClient.js
        |     hooks/  useProjects.js, useSkills.js, useProfile.js,
        |             useExperience.js, useEducation.js, useMessages.js,
        |             useAuth.js
        |-- admin/
        |     layout/      AdminLayout.jsx, Sidebar.jsx, Topbar.jsx
        |     pages/       Login, Dashboard, Projects, ProjectForm,
        |                  Skills, Experience, Education, Profile,
        |                  Messages, Settings
        |     components/  DataTable, ImageUploader, TagInput,
        |                  ConfirmModal, StatCard, ProtectedRoute
        |-- portfolio/
        |     pages/       Home, AllProjects, ProjectDetails, NotFound
        |     sections/    Hero, About, Armory, Conquests, Chronicles, Summon
        |     three/       MaskScene, Mask, Embers, Lights, SceneLoader
        |     components/  Navbar, Footer, ProjectCard, SkillCard,
        |                  TimelineItem, Cursor, IntroScreen, Marquee
        |-- animations/    Reveal, StaggerGroup, SplitText, useLenis,
        |                  useScrollTimeline, MagneticButton, Counter
        |-- shared/        Button, Input, Textarea, Modal, Skeleton, Toast
        |-- store/         authStore.js, uiStore.js
        |-- utils/         formatDate.js, constants.js
        |-- App.jsx, main.jsx, index.css

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SECTION 5: DATABASE MODELS (WRITE THESE YOURSELF)
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Admin:       email (unique), password (hashed), createdAt
Profile:     name, title, tagline, bio, photoUrl, resumeUrl, location,
             email, phone, socials {github, linkedin, twitter, leetcode},
             yearsOfExperience, stats [{label, value}]
Project:     title, slug (unique), shortDescription, longDescription,
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              techStack [String], images [{url, publicId}], liveUrl,
              githubUrl, featured (Boolean), order (Number), createdAt
Skill:        name, category (Frontend/Backend/Database/Tools), level 0-100,
              icon, order
Experience:   company, role, startDate, endDate, current (Boolean),
              description [String bullets], techUsed [String], order
Education:    institution, degree, startYear, endYear, grade, order
Message:      name, email, subject, message, read (Boolean), createdAt

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SECTION 6: API ENDPOINTS
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AUTH
  POST   /api/auth/register      (run once, then disable)
  POST   /api/auth/login         (sets httpOnly cookie)
  POST   /api/auth/logout
  GET    /api/auth/me            (check if logged in)
  PUT    /api/auth/password      (change password)

PROFILE
  GET    /api/profile            (public)
  PUT    /api/profile            (admin, with photo and resume upload)

PROJECTS
  GET    /api/projects           (public, supports ?featured=true)
  GET    /api/projects/:slug     (public)
  POST   /api/projects           (admin, multiple images)
  PUT    /api/projects/:id       (admin)
  DELETE /api/projects/:id       (admin, also deletes Cloudinary images)

SKILLS / EXPERIENCE / EDUCATION (same pattern)
  GET    /api/skills             (public)
  POST   /api/skills             (admin)
  PUT    /api/skills/:id         (admin)
  DELETE /api/skills/:id         (admin)
  ...same for /api/experience and /api/education

MESSAGES
  POST   /api/messages           (public, rate limited)
  GET    /api/messages           (admin, pagination + search)
  PUT    /api/messages/:id/read  (admin)
  DELETE /api/messages/:id       (admin)

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SECTION 7: PAGES TO DESIGN (FIGMA, DESKTOP + MOBILE)
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PUBLIC PORTFOLIO (5 pages)
  1. Intro / Loader screen: progress bar, KKV logo, "Enter the Empire" button.
  2. Home (single long scroll page) containing:
       a. Hero - The Throne Room: 3D mask, name, title, tagline,
          "View Conquests" and "Download Resume" buttons.
       b. About - The Ruler: bio, photo, stat counters, resume button.
       c. Skills - The Armory: skills grouped by category as relic cards.
       d. Projects - Conquests: featured project grid + "View all" link.
       e. Chronicles: vertical timeline for experience and education.
       f. Summon Me: contact form + social links + footer.
  3. All Projects page: grid with filter by tech stack.
  4. Project Details page: image gallery, long description, tech tags,
     live and GitHub buttons, next/previous project.
  5. 404 page: themed ("This land does not exist in the empire").

ADMIN PANEL (9 pages)
  1. Login
  2. Dashboard: counts (projects, skills, unread messages), recent messages
  3. Projects list + Add/Edit Project form
  4. Skills manager
  5. Experience manager
  6. Education manager
  7. Profile/About editor (photo, resume, socials)
  8. Messages inbox (read/unread, search, pagination, delete)
  9. Settings (change password, logout)

Total: 5 public pages + 9 admin pages, each with a mobile version.

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SECTION 8: SECTION-BY-SECTION BLUEPRINT (CONTENT + BACKEND + ANIMATION)
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A. ABOUT (The Ruler)
   Backend:   Profile model, GET/PUT /api/profile.
   Admin:     One form. Fields: name, title, tagline, bio, photo upload,
              resume PDF upload, location, email, socials, stats.
   Public:    Bio, photo, stat counters, "Download Resume" button.
   Animation: Heading reveals line by line. Counters count up on scroll.
              Photo has a mask-reveal or gentle parallax effect.

B. SKILLS (The Armory)
   Backend:   Skill model, CRUD routes.
   Admin:     Table with add, edit, delete, reorder.
   Public:    Skills grouped by category as glowing relic cards.
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   Animation: Cards fade up with stagger. Level bars fill on scroll.
              Cards float gently and tilt on hover. Optional marquee strip.

C. PROJECTS (Conquests)
   Backend:   Project model, CRUD, slug generation, multi-image upload.
   Admin:     Form with title, descriptions, tag input, multi-image uploader,
              links, featured toggle, order field.
   Public:    Featured grid on Home, All Projects page, Project Details page.
   Animation: Stagger in on scroll. 3D tilt + green glow on hover. Image
              reveal. Smooth transition from card to details page.
              Gallery slider on the details page.

D. EXPERIENCE + EDUCATION (Chronicles)
   Backend:   Experience and Education models, CRUD.
   Admin:     Two forms and two tables.
   Public:    Vertical timeline.
   Animation: The center line draws itself as you scroll (ScrollTrigger
              scrub). Entries slide in from alternating sides.

E. CONTACT (Summon Me)
   Backend:   Message model, POST (public, rate limited), email notification.
   Admin:     Inbox with unread badge, search, pagination, delete.
   Public:    Form with validation, success/error toasts, social links.
   Animation: Glowing focus borders, button loading state and success
              animation, subtle ember effect in the background.

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SECTION 9: DAY-BY-DAY SCHEDULE
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=== MONTH 1: BACKEND + ADMIN PANEL ===

--- WEEK 1: BACKEND FOUNDATIONS ---
Mon (1.5h)  Install Node, VS Code, Git, Postman. Create repo with server/ and
            client/. Run npm init, install express mongoose dotenv cors
            nodemon. Build a "hello" route. Push to GitHub.
Tue (1.5h)  Create MongoDB Atlas cluster. Write config/db.js. Use .env for the
            connection string. Confirm "MongoDB connected".
Wed (2h)    Build the Project model and full CRUD (controller + routes).
            Add slug generation.
Thu (2h)    Test every route in Postman. Write the central error-handling
            middleware and an async wrapper.
Fri (2h)    Build the Skill model, controller, and routes.
Sat (5-6h)  Build Experience, Education, and Message models and routes.
            Organize code into models/controllers/routes folders.
Sun (5-6h)  Build the Profile model and routes. Review the whole week,
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            refactor, write notes of what you learned.
Side task (15 min/day): generate 10+ mask concepts with AI, save favorites.

--- WEEK 2: AUTH, SECURITY, UPLOADS ---
Mon (1.5h)  Learn how JWT and bcrypt work. Experiment in a scratch file:
            hash a password, compare, sign and verify a token.
Tue (2h)    Admin register (run once, then disable it) and login.
Wed (2h)    Auth middleware. Send JWT as an httpOnly cookie. Protect all
            POST/PUT/DELETE routes. Add logout and /me.
Thu (2h)    Add helmet, CORS with credentials, rate limiting, mongo-sanitize,
            and request validation.
Fri (2h)    Multer (memory storage) + Cloudinary upload and delete helpers.
Sat (5-6h)  Resume PDF upload, project featured flag and order field, message
            pagination + search, email notification with Nodemailer/Resend.
Sun (5-6h)  Test every endpoint again in Postman. Fix bugs. Write the
            backend README. Push. BACKEND IS DONE.
Side task:  pick the final mask concept and run it through Meshy/Tripo.

--- WEEK 3: ADMIN PANEL UI (DUMMY DATA FIRST) ---
Mon (2h)    Set up Vite + Tailwind + React Router. Build the Login page.
Tue (2h)    Admin layout: sidebar, topbar, content area. Responsive.
Wed (2h)    Dashboard with stat cards (dummy numbers).
Thu (2h)    Learn React Hook Form + Zod. Build the Add/Edit Project form.
Fri (2h)    Projects table (DataTable), ImageUploader, TagInput components.
Sat (5-6h)  Skills, Experience, Education, and Profile forms and tables.
Sun (5-6h)  Messages page, Settings page, shared Modal, Toast, ConfirmModal.

--- WEEK 4: CONNECT TO API + DEPLOY ---
Mon (2h)    Axios client (withCredentials) + TanStack Query setup.
Tue (2h)    Connect login. Zustand auth store. ProtectedRoute wrapper.
Wed (2h)    Connect Projects CRUD with image upload.
Thu (2h)    Connect Skills, Experience, Education.
Fri (2h)    Connect Profile, resume upload, Messages. Add loading, empty,
            and error states everywhere.
Sat (5-6h)  Test every admin feature end to end. Fix bugs and UI issues.
Sun (5-6h)  Deploy backend (Render/Railway) and admin (Vercel). Fix
            production CORS and cookie settings. Add your REAL content:
            projects, skills, bio, experience. MONTH 1 DONE.
Side task:  clean up the AI-generated mask in Blender.

=== MONTH 2: PUBLIC PORTFOLIO + ANIMATIONS ===

--- WEEK 5: DESIGN + 2D BUILD ---
Mon (2h)    Make the KKV logo. Finalize palette and fonts. Generate AI UI
            mockups for inspiration only.
Tue (2h)    Final Figma layouts (desktop + mobile). Write all copy with
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             Claude, then rewrite it in your own voice.
Wed (2h)     Navbar, Footer, layout shell. Tailwind theme with your colors.
Thu (2h)     Hero (2D version) and About section from the API.
Fri (2h)     Armory (skills) from the API.
Sat (5-6h)   Conquests grid, All Projects page with filter, Project Details.
Sun (5-6h)   Chronicles timeline, Summon Me form (saves to DB), responsive
             fixes across all sections.

--- WEEK 6: THE 3D MASK ---
Mon (2h)     Three.js concepts: scene, camera, mesh, light, render loop.
Tue (2h)     Install R3F + drei. Render a spinning cube. Learn useFrame.
Wed (2h)     Materials (metalness, roughness), Environment maps, lighting.
Thu (2h)     Finalize the mask in Blender: remove junk geometry, reduce to
             30k-80k triangles, fix materials, export .glb.
Fri (2h)     Compress with gltf-transform + Draco (under 3 MB). Load with
             useGLTF in the Hero.
Sat (5-6h)   Eye glow with bloom, mouse-follow rotation, idle floating motion.
Sun (5-6h)   Fog, ember particles, throne-room background, 3D loader with
             progress bar.

--- WEEK 7: ANIMATIONS ---
Mon (2h)     GSAP + ScrollTrigger practice (gsap.context cleanup in React).
Tue (2h)     Build Reveal, StaggerGroup, SplitText. Apply to all sections.
Wed (2h)     Lenis smooth scroll, counters, marquee strip.
Thu (2h)     Scroll-linked camera: mask rotates/moves as you scroll sections.
Fri (2h)     Project card tilt + glow, floating skill relics, self-drawing
             timeline.
Sat (5-6h)   Intro screen ("Enter the Empire"), page transitions, custom
             cursor, magnetic buttons.
Sun (5-6h)   Optional sound with mute toggle, animation polish,
             prefers-reduced-motion support.

--- WEEK 8: OPTIMIZE + LAUNCH ---
Mon (2h)     Mobile fallback (static image or very light 3D), lazy-load the
             3D scene, code splitting.
Tue (2h)     Lighthouse audit. Compress model and images.
Wed (2h)     SEO tags (react-helmet-async), Open Graph image, favicon,
             accessibility basics (alt text, focus states, contrast).
Thu (2h)     Deploy the frontend. Set env variables. Test live.
Fri (2h)     Test on multiple phones and browsers. Fix bugs.
Sat (5-6h)   Write a strong README with screenshots. Buy a custom domain
             (example: keerthikumarv.dev). Final polish.
Sun (5-6h)   LAUNCH. Share on LinkedIn and GitHub. Add the link to your resume.

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SECTION 10: AI DESIGN WORKFLOW (PROMPTS)
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Mask concept art (Midjourney / Ideogram / Flux):
  "Original sci-fi armored ruler mask, hooded dark green cloak, riveted
  brushed-steel faceplate, narrow glowing green eye slits, engraved KKV
  crest on forehead, front view, symmetrical, centered, studio lighting,
  dark background, ultra detailed, 3D render style"
  Generate front, side, and 3/4 views in the same style.

Image to 3D:
  Upload the front image to Meshy / Tripo3D. Generate. Then in Blender:
  remove stray geometry, reduce polygons (30k-80k), fix metal/roughness
  materials, export .glb, compress with Draco to under 3 MB.

Logo (Ideogram):
  "Minimal metallic monogram KKV, sharp angular letters, steel with green
  glow, black background, vector style"

UI mockup (v0 / Figma Make) - reference only:
  "Dark cinematic developer portfolio for Keerthi Kumar V, steel and glowing
  green palette, gold accents, serif headings, sections: hero with central
  mask, about, skill grid, project cards, timeline, contact form"

Copywriting (Claude):
  Ask for a bio, section intros in an "empire ruler" tone, and project
  descriptions. Edit all of it so it sounds like you.

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SECTION 11: ANIMATIONS THAT IMPRESS RECRUITERS
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MUST-HAVE
  1. 3D mask hero that follows the mouse, with green eye glow (bloom).
  2. Cinematic intro with progress bar and "Enter the Empire" button.
  3. Smooth scrolling across the whole site (Lenis).
  4. Text reveal: headings animate line by line or letter by letter.
  5. Scroll-linked camera: mask rotates/moves as sections change.
  6. Self-drawing timeline in Chronicles (ScrollTrigger scrub).
  7. Project cards with 3D tilt, glow, and image reveal on hover.
  8. Page transitions between Home and Project Details.

NICE-TO-HAVE
  9. Custom cursor with a green glow trail.
 10. Magnetic buttons that pull toward the cursor.
 11. Counters counting up (years, projects, technologies).
 12. Skill cards floating gently like relics.
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 13. Ember particles floating up in Hero and Contact.
 14. Marquee strip of tech names.
 15. Contact button success animation.
 16. Optional sound with a mute toggle.

PERFORMANCE RULES RECRUITERS NOTICE
  - 60fps: animate only transform and opacity.
  - No layout jumps: reserve space for images and 3D canvas.
  - Fast load: mask model under 3 MB, lazy-load 3D.
  - Mobile fallback: lighter or static hero on phones.
  - Respect prefers-reduced-motion.
  - Skeleton loaders while API data loads.
  A smooth, fast site beats a flashy, laggy one.

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SECTION 12: WHAT TO LEARN (FOCUSED, NOT BASICS)
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Express ........ Router/controller structure, middleware, error handling.
Mongoose ....... Schemas, validation, slugs, indexes, pagination, search.
Auth ........... JWT in httpOnly cookie, bcrypt, protected routes, logout.
Security ....... Helmet, CORS with credentials, rate limit, sanitization.
Uploads ........ Multer memory storage, Cloudinary upload and delete.
React .......... Custom hooks, layout routes, protected routes.
TanStack Query . useQuery, useMutation, invalidateQueries, loading/error.
Forms .......... React Hook Form + Zod, file inputs, dynamic tag fields.
Tailwind ....... Custom theme tokens, responsive design, dark theme.
GSAP ........... Timelines, ScrollTrigger (scrub, pin, stagger), cleanup.
R3F ............ Canvas, useFrame, useGLTF, lights, Environment, bloom.
3D assets ...... Blender cleanup, polygon reduction, Draco compression.
Performance .... Lazy loading, code splitting, image compression, Lighthouse.
Deployment ..... Env variables, production CORS, cross-domain cookies
                 (sameSite and secure settings).

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SECTION 13: LAUNCH CHECKLIST
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[ ] All five sections load from the API (no hardcoded data)
[ ] Every section can be edited from the admin panel
[ ] Contact form saves to DB and emails you
[ ] Resume download works
[ ] Login, logout, and protected routes work in production
[ ] Image uploads work in production
[ ] 3D mask loads under 3 MB with a loader
[ ] Mobile fallback works on a real phone
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[ ] Animations are smooth on a mid-range phone
[ ] Loading, empty, and error states exist everywhere
[ ] Lighthouse performance above 80 on desktop
[ ] SEO tags, Open Graph image, favicon added
[ ] README with screenshots, live link, and tech stack
[ ] Secrets are not in Git (.env in .gitignore)
[ ] Custom domain connected (optional)

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SECTION 14: WHAT RECRUITERS LOOK AT
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1. The live link loads fast and works on mobile.
2. Real projects with live demos and GitHub links.
3. A clean README and organized repo.
4. The admin panel as proof of full-stack skill (auth, CRUD, uploads).
5. Polished but smooth animations.
6. A clear About section and an easy resume download.

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SECTION 15: IF YOU FALL BEHIND
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Cut in this order:
  1. Sound
  2. Custom cursor and magnetic buttons
  3. Ember particles
  4. Marquee and extra counters
  5. Page transitions
Never cut: backend, admin panel, the 3D mask, mobile fallback, deployment.

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START TODAY
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1. Generate 10 original mask concepts with AI (15 minutes).
2. Do Week 1, Monday: install tools, create the repo with server/ and
   client/, build your first Express route, push to GitHub.

Good luck, Keerthi. Build the empire.
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